

Session 2

Customer Understanding



WINNIE NGUYEN

Senior Product Designer at NAB
Former Senior Product Designer at Go1
Former Product Design Instructor at StayLab



Agenda

What We're Building Today

Build the ability to gather genuine user understanding — not assumptions

1. Friction metric
2. Assumptions - Surface what you believe
3. Research questions - Define what to learn
4. User interview - Go talk with real people
5. Synthesis - Make sense of findings

MINDSET SHIFT

“

You are not your user

Your intuition is shaped by who YOU are, no who your users are

I think users want this...

Our users are like me...

I know what the problem is



I wonder what users actually do...

Our users are different from me

I have a hypothesis worth testing

Part 1

Friction Metrics

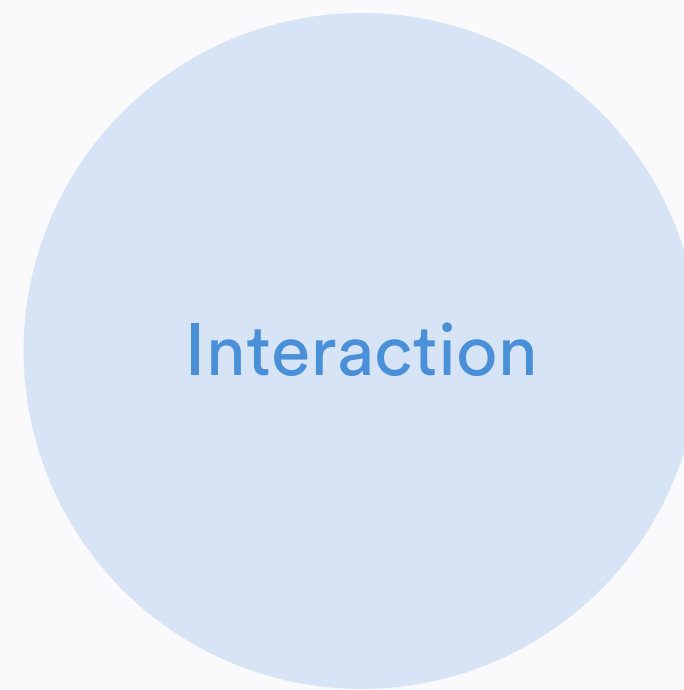
What is friction metric?

Friction, in UX and product design, refers to anything that slows a user down, confuses them, or prevents them from completing what they set out to do. A friction metric is a measurable signal that quantifies that difficulty.



Cognitive

Too much to think



Interaction

Hard to do



Emotional

Feels wrong or risky

When to use

Maps measurement to the full product lifecycle: discovery/baseline → design/prototyping → post-launch → ongoing. Includes a quick-reference table.

Why to use

Covers the business, design, and user case with the core argument that friction metrics turn opinion-based debates into evidence.

How to use

- Step 1: Define the flow and the goal
- Step 2: Choose your metrics
- Step 3: Set up measurement
- Analyse and identify friction points

Friction Analysis: Current Experience

User Step	Friction Observed	Friction Type	Severity	Why It Matters
e.g. Sign up / Onboarding	Too many fields to fill in at once	Cognitive	High	Users abandon before completing
e.g. Finding a feature	Navigation is unclear, buried 3 levels deep	Interaction	Medium	Lowers task completion rate
e.g. Submitting a form	No confirmation feedback after submission	Emotional	High	User feels uncertain — trust is lost
e.g. Error recovery	Error message is vague, no guidance to fix	Cognitive	Medium	Increases frustration & support tickets

Friction Analysis: Proposed Stage Experience

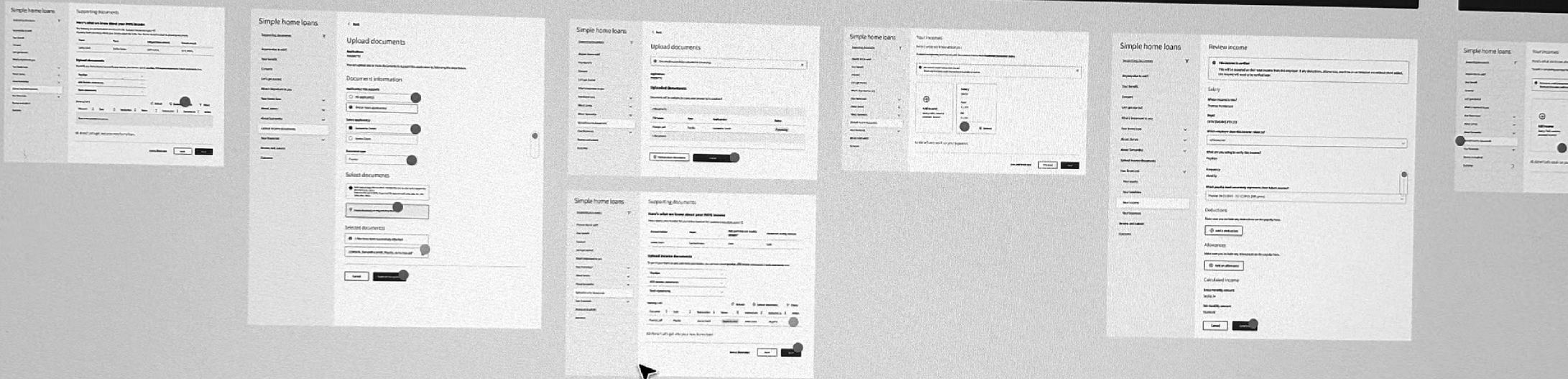
User Step	Friction Reduced / Eliminated	Design Solution	Expected Outcome	Priority
Sign up / Onboarding	Cognitive overload from long form	Progressive disclosure — break into steps	Higher completion rate	P1 — Critical
Finding a feature	Unclear navigation structure	Flatten IA + add search / shortcut	Faster task completion	P2 — High
Submitting a form	No feedback after submit	Success state + confirmation message	Builds trust, reduces anxiety	P1 — Critical
Error recovery	Vague error message, no fix guidance	Inline error + actionable hint text	Fewer drop-offs, better recovery	P2 — High

capture

Simple Home Loan - Capture

Capture experience (e.g Upload payslip → capture income - Banker)

Capture ex



Capture experience (e.g Upload document → capture information)

27 TAPS

Capture e

Friction Analysis

IMP Friction Analysis

We've reduced friction by approximately 60% measured by lower tap counts and streamlined steps/pages

Metrics	Roles	Before	After	Reduction (%)
Capture experience (e.g Upload document → capture information)	Banker	27	13	-52%
Capture experience (e.g Capture information → Upload document)	Banker	30	10	-67%
Verification (e.g Verify income only)	Assessor	7	8	+14%
Capture information and upload document	Assessor	35	9	-74%
Total		99	40	-60%

PRACTICE 1

10 MINS

A Simple Friction Review

Write down everything you currently believe about your user. No filtering.

How to do it:

1. Choose one key user journey (e.g., checkout, sign-up, first use)
2. Record current taps, clicks and scroll
3. Set up a friction analysis table

Part 2

Assumptions

What is an Assumption?

Anything you believe about your user, problem, or product without evidence to confirm it

01

User Assumption

Our users are 25-35 and tech savvy

02

Problem Assumption

This problem is real and urgent

03

Solution Assumption

A start rating will build trust

04

Business Assumption

User will pay \$99/month

Assumptions aren't bad. Hidden assumptions are

How to write one

**We believe that [WHO] will [WHAT] because [WHY].
We'll know this is true when [SIGNAL].**

Weak

Users will like the app

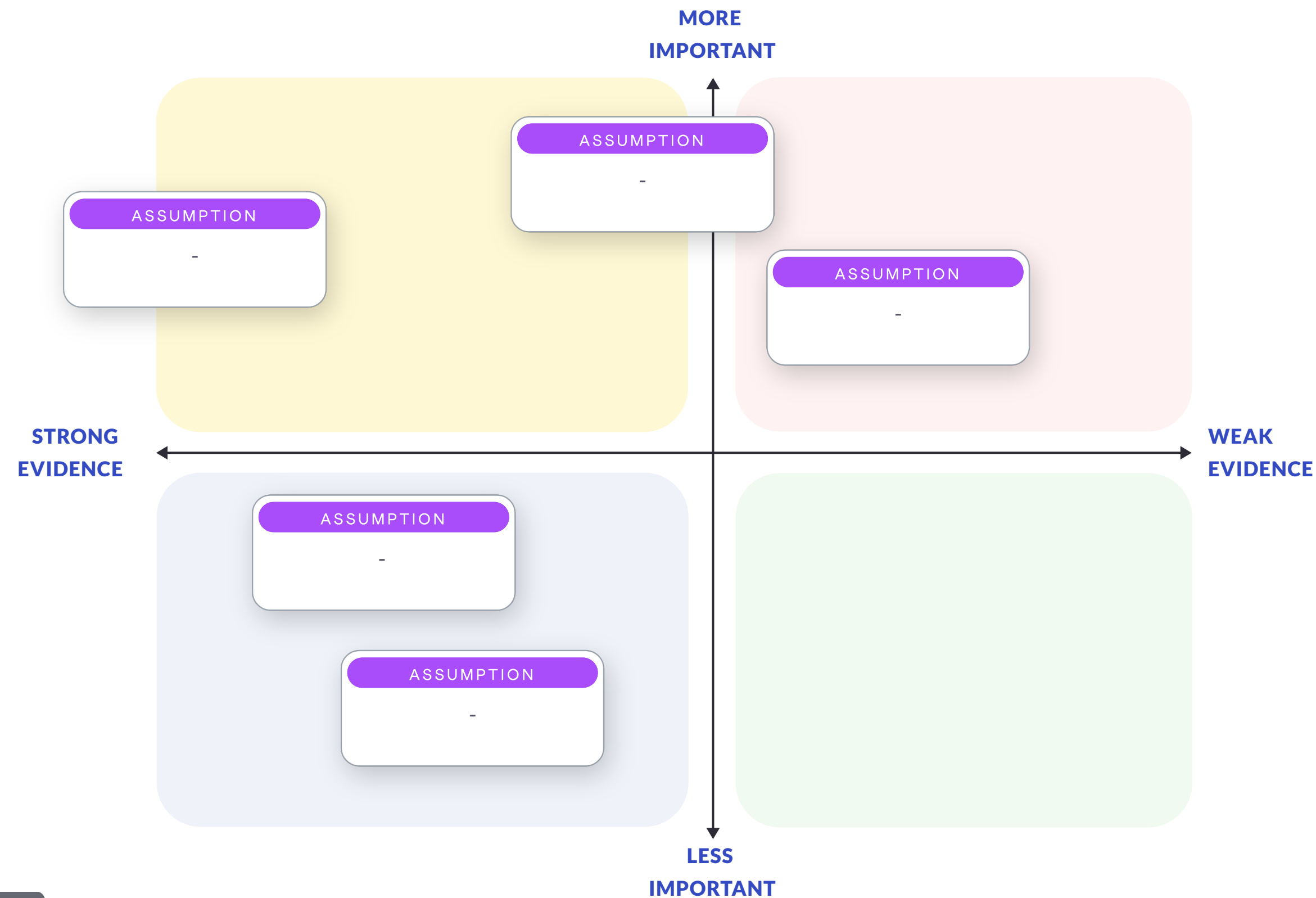
People hate slow loading

Strong

We believe freelance designers will log time daily because they struggle to invoice accurately. We'll know this when 60% log a session in week 1

We believe mobile users will abandon checkout if load time exceeds 4 sec. We'll know this when abandonment rate correlates with load time in analytics

THE ASSUMPTION MAP



Test first

High importance, low confidence, validate before you design

Validate early

High importance, high confidence, still worth checking

Monitor later

Low importance, low confidence, not worth research spending now

Safe to proceed

Low importance, high confidence, move forward

When to run it?

01 Before you design anything

03 When the team is disagreeing

05 Before pitching to stakeholders

02 Before committing to a big feature

04 After every round of user research

PRACTICE 1

10 MINS

Create assumptions

Write down everything you currently believe about your user. No filtering.

How to do it:

- Using AI to write 5 assumptions about this product using the formula.
 - Embed resource to AI for training
 - Use prompt to do
- **Debrief together (5 min)**
 - Which assumptions overlap?
 - What did AI miss that you caught?
 - Which AI assumption is the weakest — and how would you fix it?



AI PROMPT

“I am building [product name] for [target user]. Generate 5 assumptions I might have about this product — covering user behavior, user needs, technical feasibility, and business viability. Write each assumption using this formula: I believe [user/stakeholder] will [action/behavior] because [reason]. Flag which assumptions are riskiest and why.”

Part 3

Research Questions

Research questions

What

- A focused question that guides what you need to learn from users — rooted in an assumption you want to validate or disprove
- Not a survey question or a yes/no — it's open-ended and exploratory

How

- Starts with the assumption — then asks what you still need to learn to prove or disprove it
- Write it as: “What do we need to understand about [user behavior / problem / context] in order to [make this design decision]?”

When

- After you've mapped your assumptions and identified which ones are most risky or unknown
- Before planning your interview guide it becomes the anchor for every interview question you write
- Revisit if your assumption changes — one assumption = one research question

From assumption to interview guide

1 assumption → 1 primary research question → 5-8 interview questions



Interview questions (5-8 per research questions)

Why research question matter

01 Prevent scope creep

03 Connect to an assumption

02 Force clarity on purpose

04 Focus synthesis

Good vs Bad research questions

Weak

Do users like our product?

What features do users want?

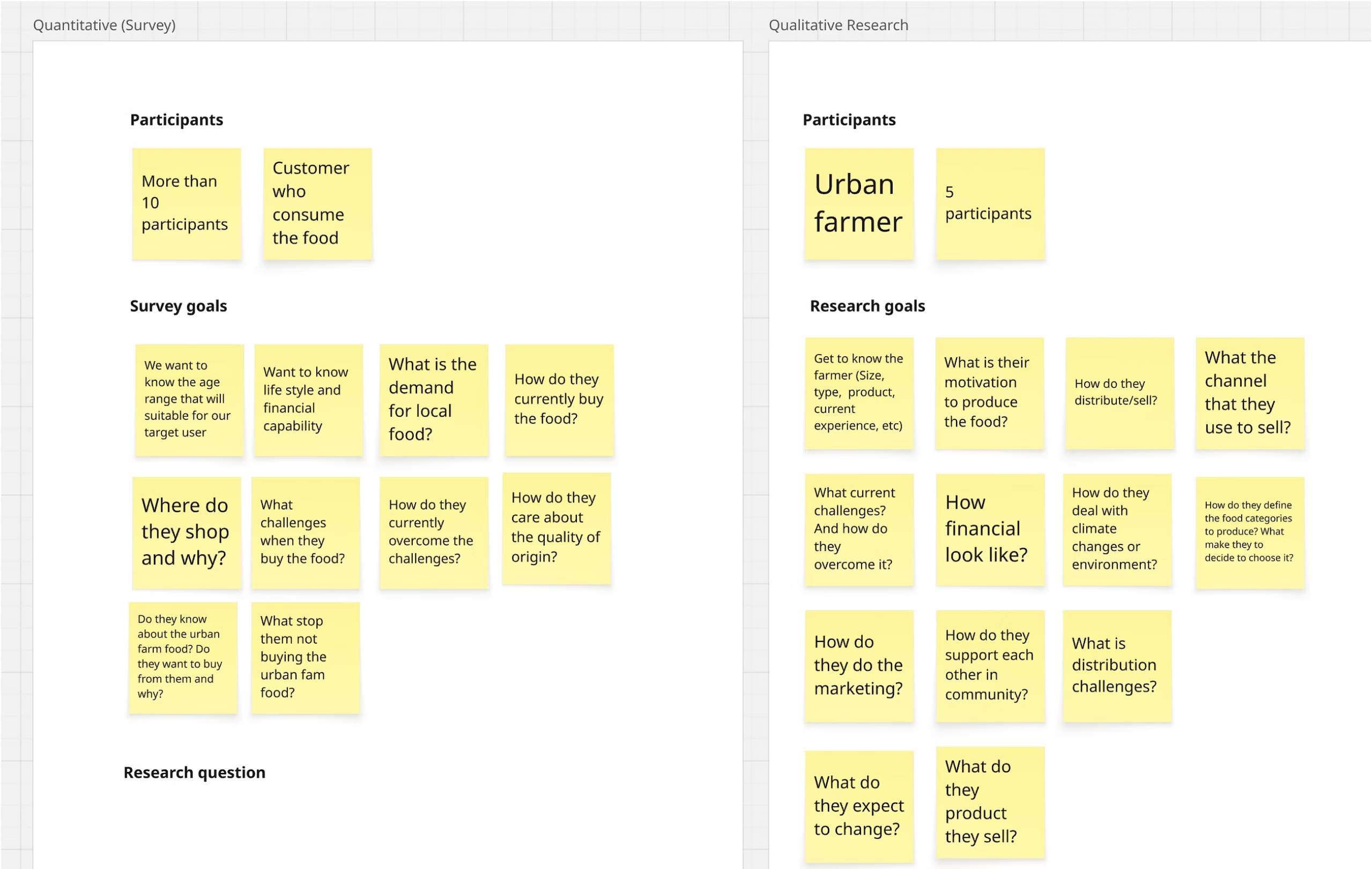
Why don't user trust us?

Strong

What moment in onboarding causes users to disengage, and what do they believe at that moment?

What workarounds are users for [task], and what do those reveal about the unmet needs?

What signals do users look for before submitting payment?



Winnie’s team - Urban Farming research

PRACTICE 1

10 MINS

Prepare Research Questions

TBD

How to do it:

- TBD



AI PROMPT

TBD

Part 4

User Interview

Interview Fundamentals

Ask open questions

"How do you currently do this?" — not "Do you like this?"

Follow the story

When something sounds interesting, dig: 'Tell me more about that.'

Stay curious, not leading

Never confirm assumptions. Let their answer surprise you.

Listen more than you talk

Silence is OK. Wait. Let them fill the space first.

Observe, don't just hear

What they do ≠ what they say they do. Note both.



Golden rule: Understand their world — don't validate your solution.

How AI Helps at This Stage

AI is your research thinking partner — not a replacement for real conversations.



Generate & pressure-test assumptions

Dump what you think you know. AI flags stereotypes and gaps you didn't notice.



Co-write interview questions

Give AI your user type + topic. Review and pick the best open-ended questions.



Synthesize messy notes

Paste raw interview notes. AI maps observations to Empathy Map quadrants.



Challenge your thinking

Ask: 'What would prove this assumption wrong?' — builds real research rigour.

Part 5

Assignment

Your Deliverables

HW 2

Assumption Mapping

- List 10 assumptions about your user
- Mark each: High / Medium / Low confidence
- Identify 3 assumptions to test via research
- Deliverable: Annotated assumption list

HW 1

Conduct a User Interview

- 60-min interview with a real person
- Use AI-prepared questions as your guide
- Record detailed notes or transcript
- Deliverable: Written notes + reflection



Want to make a presentation like this one?

Start with a fully customizable template, create a beautiful deck in minutes, then easily share it with anyone.

Create a presentation (It's free)